

Handout: Camus – *The Myth of Sisyphus*

Suicide, Absurdity, and the Affirmation of Life

I. Historical and Philosophical Background

Albert Camus (1913–1960)

- Born in Algeria, a French colony, Camus lived through colonial inequality, WWII, and the Nazi occupation of France.
 - He was associated with **French existentialists** (notably Sartre), but ultimately *rejected the existentialist label*, aligning himself instead with a unique philosophy of **the Absurd**.
 - His **Absurdist Triptych** includes:
 - **Novel:** *The Stranger*
 - **Essay:** *The Myth of Sisyphus*
 - **Play:** *Caligula*
 - Published during WWII (1942), *The Myth of Sisyphus* captures the intellectual despair of the age, particularly amidst the horrors of war and the collapse of Enlightenment rationalism.
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II. Framing the Problem: The Absurd and Suicide

“There is only one really serious philosophical problem... and that is suicide.” (MS, 3)

The Problem:

- Camus opens with the dramatic claim that the central philosophical question is whether life is worth living.

- This is not merely theoretical. For Camus, the conclusion of philosophy must be **actionable**: how shall we live?

The Absurd:

- The Absurd arises from a confrontation: **the human desire for meaning** meets **the world's silence**.
- Camus insists that life offers no *transcendent meaning* or rational structure. We ask questions, but the universe does not answer.

"This world in itself is not reasonable, that is all that can be said." (MS, 21)

Suicide as a Response?

- Suicide is a temptation that arises from recognizing absurdity.
- But Camus refuses to accept suicide as a valid solution. Rather, it is a **flight from the problem**, a form of philosophical surrender.

III. The Absurd Sensibility and Limits of Reason

"The absurd is an experience that must be lived through." (R, 4)

- Camus does not argue that life *is* absurd; he instead *describes* a **mood or sensibility**.
- The "absurd sensibility" is akin to a modern disease — an intellectual and existential unease.
- Camus's tone is descriptive, not analytic. He avoids formal proofs and instead uses **images and metaphors** (e.g., the collapse of daily routines).

Limits of Reason:

- Camus critiques science and philosophy for their failed attempts to impose order on chaos.

- He sees this desire for rational unity as a dangerous **nostalgia**.
- **Knowledge fails us** because it cannot satisfy our existential hunger.

“With the exception of professional rationalists, people today despair of true knowledge.” (MS, 18)

IV. Camus vs. Existentialists

Shared Starting Point:

- Like Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Sartre, and Nietzsche, Camus begins from the recognition of **the death of God** and **life’s lack of intrinsic meaning**.

Critical Divergence:

- Camus accuses the existentialists of **leaping into irrational hope**.
- He rejects **Kierkegaard’s leap of faith**, **Heidegger’s Being-toward-death**, and even **Sartre’s project of creating meaning through freedom**, as betrayals of the absurd.

“They deify what crushes them... That forced hope is religious in all of them.” (MS, 24)

- While Sartre tries to make sense of contingency and build an ethics of freedom, Camus insists this is **bad faith**. Absurdity, for him, is **not ontological** (as in Sartre), but **relational** — a product of human desire and an indifferent world.
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V. Revolt as the Absurd Response

“Die unreconciled and not of one’s own free will.” (MS, 55)

Rejecting Suicide and Hope

- Camus’s response to absurdity is **lucid revolt**:

- Reject suicide.
- Reject religious or ideological hope.
- Embrace life *as it is*, with full awareness of its meaninglessness.

Revolt:

- Revolt is not a one-time act, but a continuous **defiance**, a **refusal to be consoled**, and an insistence on **facing limits without resignation**.
 - It is a life lived **without appeal** — *no gods, no metaphysics, no utopias*.
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VI. The Myth of Sisyphus: The Absurd Hero

“One must imagine Sisyphus happy.” (MS, 123)

- Sisyphus becomes Camus’s **symbol of absurd consciousness**.
- His punishment — endlessly rolling a rock up a hill — is the **quintessential absurd task**.
- Yet, in his awareness of the absurdity, **Sisyphus transcends his fate**.

Key Points:

- His consciousness during descent is crucial: **awareness turns punishment into resistance**.
 - His fate is **his own** — he no longer looks for meaning outside himself.
 - Camus sees in him a tragic joy: “The struggle itself toward the heights is enough to fill a man’s heart.”
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VII. Absurd Happiness

"Happiness and the absurd are two sons of the same earth." (MS, 122)

What Kind of Happiness?

- Camus's happiness is not conventional joy but a form of **lucid living**.
- It is the joy of living *intensely in the present*, aware of death, finitude, and absurdity.